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CLIMATE



## Former Tesla president discloses the secret to scaling a company

Few companies have grown as quickly as Tesla, especially just before and after the company launched the Model 3, its first affordable EV.

"We scaled Tesla in 30 months from \$2 billion in revenue to \$20 billion in revenue," Jon McNeill, the former president of Tesla who is now co-founder and CEO of DVx Ventures, told the crowd at TechCrunch's All Stage event in Boston.

It wasn't McNeill's first time scaling companies, nor would it be his last. Previously, he founded six different companies, and after Tesla, he joined Lyft as COO before starting his own venture firm.

Over the years, he has helped him identify those insights that will shape Stage 2025.

When assessing a startup, he primarily judges market fit and then focuses on the team. He breaks this into two objectives:

For product-market fit, he asks each startup, "Do 40% of your customers say they cannot live without your product?" he said. If not, then the company isn't ready.

"We keep adding, adding, adding and tweaking the product until we get to 40% and then we say, okay, boom, now we've got product-market fit," McNeill said. "It's actually objective and measured. It's not a feeling; it's not a sense. It's a metric."

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McNeill added, “We did a study of businesses that actually achieved breakout, and those businesses achieved breakout at roughly that 40% acceptance level.”

Second, McNeill looks at whether the company has a mature go-to-market strategy. Specifically, he’s interested in whether the amount a company spends to acquire customers, known as customer acquisition cost (CAC), is sufficiently below the total lifetime value of a customer for the company.

When a company’s CAC is too high, it can eat into the life of the company. Specifically, he’s interested in whether the amount a company spends to acquire customers, known as customer acquisition cost (CAC), is sufficiently below the total lifetime value of a customer for the company.

“Then we paid cash \$100,000,” he said.

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Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including Wired magazine, the...

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TRANSPORTATION



Tesla vet says that  
‘reviewing real products’ —  
not mock-ups — is the key  
to staying innovative

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GM's EVs have taken the lead in the U.S. — Chevy Bolt for example — but Tesla's fully electrified vehicles — has pushed the automaker into second place in the U.S. behind Tesla.

How did it get there? With a little help from a Tesla veteran.

GM board member Jon McNeill was president of Tesla during the development and introduction of the Model 3, a crucial period of the company's growth. One of the things he credits for Tesla's success is how Elon Musk ran product meetings.

“No slides was our first rule,” McNeill told the audience earlier this month at TC All Stage in Boston. “You have to be reviewing real product.”

Every week, senior leadership would sit down with product leaders to review their progress. The practice was inspired by an encounter Musk had with Steve Jobs, McNeill said.



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“There was this belief that I think is true: Steve Jobs didn’t have a ton of time or patience for Elon in the early days. And early in the early days, Elon would try to chase Steve down at events and parties in Silicon Valley for advice. And Steve didn’t like Elon, and so would often turn his back to him when he approached him.

“But one night, Elon got lucky and said, ‘Steve, if you had one piece of advice for me as a young entrepreneur’ — he had just

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Musk took that to heart, McNeill said, and the concept of a perfect product became central to product development at Tesla.

“The thing we were looking for first of all was surprise and delight. Like, are we doing something that is going to just make somebody go wow or laugh or have fun?

“Crazy example of that is the fart button,” McNeill said, referring to a software button labeled “Emissions Testing Mode” that would simulate flatulence through the car’s speakers.

The company also prized minimalism, which on the software side meant keeping functions accessible in fewer than two taps on the screen.

“It has to be a kind of a no-brainer for the average user. Then we would double back the designer — the lead designer was always in the room — and then we would say, OK, Franz, now make it beautiful.”

Meetings like those, where the actual product was reviewed, not a mock-up, helped preserve Tesla’s culture as it grew, McNeill said. “You can imagine the culture that gets communicated when people are bringing their A game to the CEO every week. Because you’re not going to bring your B game to the CEO — especially that CEO, because he’s going to fire you,” he said.

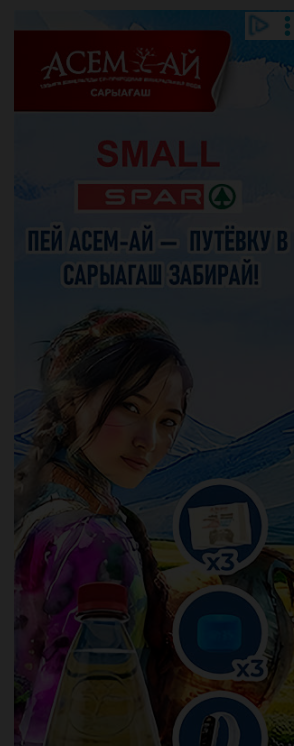
“That keeps innovation. Even if the product is not perfect, it’s still a step forward.”

McNeill left Tesla’s board at GM.

“One of the things Mark Reuss, CEO of GM, said every week was ‘product [was] in the room.’”

“That stuff is so powerful. And it’s led to GM’s introduction of 17 EVs, now the second best selling EVs in the country. Because they’re just on product, every week.”

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Lyft says its revenue is growing nearly 3x faster than Uber's

Darrell Etherington — 1:00 PM PDT · March 12, 2018



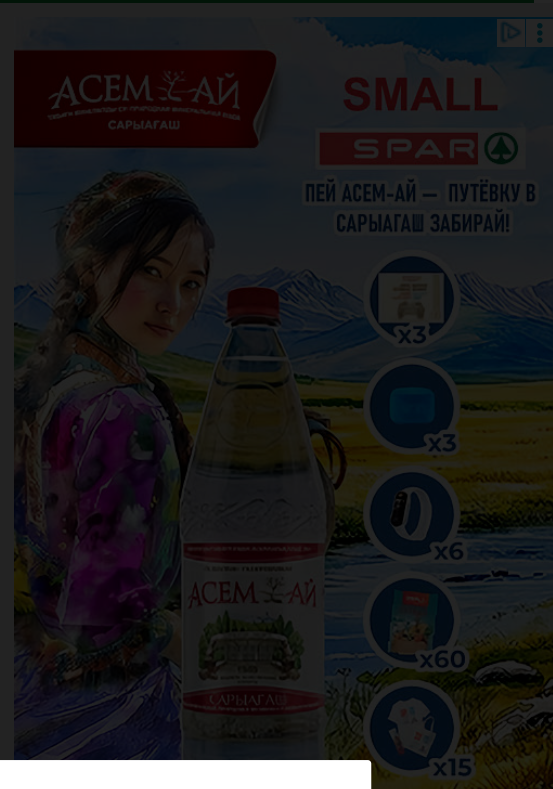
Lyft made a lot of progress in 2017, helped by strong market expansion within the U.S. and riding some very bad news from its primary rival, Uber. That's helped it grow revenue to more than \$1 billion as measured by GAAP standards for its fiscal 2017, with a particularly strong Q4 during which its revenue outpaced Uber's by 2.75x, lifted (get it?) 168 percent year-over-year, versus 61 percent growth for Uber's revenue relative to its own performance during the final quarter of 2017.

Of course, neither company needs to release their official financial results for either the quarter or the year, because they're both still private, but they do tend to enjoy letting a bit of the fiscal cat out of the bag. Lyft provided this stat shot, which also includes some highlight numbers on its performance thus far in 2018.

Lyft say it's still doing more than 10 million rides per week across the platform. The company also says that its revenue in the 31st will also be up more than 100 percent year-over-year.

Last year also saw Lyft, with a launch in Ottawa in Canada, and Tesla's Jon M. Nishi as its co-

Lyft growing, but it's surprising, however, that Uber, the clear leader when it comes to North American



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### TRANSPORTATION



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